

Illustration by **NILANJAN DAS**

Even a routine farm fire in Jalandhar was reimagined as a drone attack.

The misinformation wasn't limited to visuals. Fabricated advisories also caused panic. One WhatsApp forward, posing as a ministry of defence alert, warned of imminent war. Another urged citizens to disable location services on their mobile phones to prevent the enemy from identifying densely populated areas.

Pakistan's "ironclad friend" China joined the fray too. *China Daily*, a Central Propaganda Department-run English newspaper, falsely claimed three Indian jets had crashed in Kashmir, using a photo from 2019. Fake reports elsewhere included absurd claims—like the Indian military mistakenly bombing Amritsar from Ambala.

Unlike India, Pakistan and China have long invested in cognitive warfare capabilities. Inter-Services Public Relations (ISPR), the media wing of the Pakistan Armed Forces, has morphed into a state-run production house, churning out military-themed music videos and dramas to shape public perception. During the Operation Sindoor fallout, ISPR briefings were often held late at night—timed for western media cycles. By the time India responded, much of the damage was often already done.

THE COUNTER-OFFENSIVE

Amid this digital fog of war, India scrambled to launch a counterattack. A war room led by information and broadcasting (I&B) minister Ashwini Vaishnaw was set up, drawing on social media experts from the army's Corps of Signals and the National Cyber Coordination Centre. Every image, clip and hashtag produced by this team was an armed probe—not just to set the record straight, but also to identify Pakistani bot networks. By May 11, the ministry had issued over 20 official clarifications, warning of "Pakistan-linked accounts" trying to "flood the information space with falsehoods".

Fake stories that cast India in a negative light often "gain higher traction", says Sriparna Pathak, professor of China Studies at O.P. Jindal Global University, who has done extensive research on information warfare. The outrage such stories provoke only boosts their visibility through algorithmic amplification. Platforms like TikTok and Instagram, heavily used by Gen Z, have emerged as key propaganda tools for both Pakistan and China, adds Pathak. Interestingly, unexpected vigilantes came to the rescue—the Indian K-pop fan community mobilised to debunk misinformation and provide clarity to global followers on X, winning hearts back home.

As another expert in information warfare observed, social media enables rapid propagation of content, where users serve as both consumers and propagators. Unlike the press, it's not bound by editorial checks. Yet, traditional media, too, occasionally added to the confusion. On May 8, in the heat of the crisis, several Indian news channels breathlessly reported that the navy had destroyed Karachi Port—a claim later proved false. Some suggest this was part of psychological warfare, others blame the race for ratings.

The tools are cutting-edge, but the concept is ancient—Sun Tzu's timeless dictum of "subduing the enemy without fighting"

Either way, the current crisis underscores a stark reality. That the frontlines of conflict have expanded—from the land to the mind. The challenge will be to defend truth without blurring the line between vigilance and paranoia. ■